OBITUARY: LATA MANGESHKAR (1929-2022)

United Colours of Lata

Apart from melody and octave range, Lata Mangeshkar's songs were lit by a rare emotional intelligence

By Sunil Sethi

Getting into the car with her longstanding companion, the cricketer Raj Singh Dungarpur, at Heathrow airport, Lata Mangeshkar wagged a finger at me. "Don't forget to call. Come for lunch. I'll cook for you." All I had done was help the couple locate their mislaid luggage, so the invitation was both unexpected and impossible to resist. I only had a passing acquaintance with the formidable diva—universally known as 'Didi'—during the course of reporting, but in the hurly-burly of Mumbai's studios, these encounters are ephemeral.

But here was Lata at home, relaxed, bustling about, heaping food on our plates in the traditional way. The two made a study in contrast: she, the diminutive host in her trademark bindi and plaits; he, every inch the aristocrat. When I asked how she found the desiccated coconut in London for one of the dishes, she giggled shyly; and in that enchanting girlish voice said, "*Intezaam ki baat hai* (It's just a matter of arranging for things)."

Other than her prodigious musical talent, tireless industry and phenomenal memory, "*intezaam*" was a key note of Lata Mangeshkar's life. How else would a 13-year-old, left bereft and penniless by her father (a provincial actor-singer who died at 42) have supported her mother and four siblings on a wage of Rs 60 a month? When she first switched from small acting parts (which she loathed) to playback singing, her voice was considered thin and her Urdu pronunciation, she confessed, was awful. If punishing train journeys, rehearsals and recordings—for as many as six songs a day without food, water or sleep—weren't enough hardship, a further humiliation was that playback singers went uncredited at the time.

From rousing patriotic anthems to playful romantic ditties, lyrics of burning passion to spiritual hymns, there was no shade of human expression Lata Mangeshkar's vast repertoire left untouched

Lata Mangeshkar's life is sometimes portrayed as the ultimate feminist plot, but it is greater than the sum of its parts. Her personal struggle in the 1940s coincidentally echoed the birth of a nation. But a single song—'*Aayega Aanewala*' from the 1949 haunted house thriller *Mahal*—turned her into an overnight singing sensation. The song's exquisite prelude had been painstakingly achieved; even so, initial prints of the film and discs failed to credit her. It was only when AIR was flooded with fan mail that the singer's identity was revealed.

Chroniclers of Lata's life were awed by her powers of recall. She briskly corrected names, dates, locations and lyrics. "But that was in 1945, not 1946," she might say, highlighting an error.

Yet her melody was marked not just by a sensational memory and octave range, her songs were lit by rare emotional intelligence. Film historian Nasreen Munni Kabir, who comprehensively recorded her conversations with the maestro in *Lata Mangeshkar...in Her Own Voice* (Niyogi Books; 2009), says that if she hadn't become a singer, she would have been a psychologist. "She had an extraordinary ability to capture human feelings and the emotion behind every song. The actress Meena Kumari once said, "*Agar Lata gaa rahi hai to hamein acting karne ki kya zaroorat hai* (If Lata is singing, then we actors don't need to act)." Stars like Nargis and Madhubala only signed on films if Lata was singing for them.

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